

Language Learning Theories (ENG505)

✚ **Introduction to Language Learning:** This refers to the study of how people acquire language, including the processes, theories, and methods involved.

✚ **Historical Perspective:** This refers to the study of how language learning theories and methods have evolved over time, influenced by philosophical, psychological, and social factors. For example, ancient Greeks focused on rhetoric, while the Middle Ages emphasized religious and philosophical approaches.

✚ **Introduction to The Key Theories**

These are fundamental ideas that explain how language learning occurs:

- **Behaviorism:** Language learning is a result of external stimuli and reinforcement.
- **Cognitivism:** Language learning is a result of internal mental processes.
- **Constructivism:** Language learning is a result of active construction of knowledge by the learner.
- **Sociocultural Theory:** Language learning is influenced by social and cultural factors.

✚ **Introduction to Approaches, Methods and Techniques**

Approaches: A broad perspective or philosophy that guides language teaching and learning. Approaches are often based on theories of language acquisition, learning, and teaching. Examples of approaches include:

- Communicative Language Teaching (CLT)
- Task-Based Learning (TBL)
- Content and Language Integrated Learning (CLIL)

Methods: A specific way of implementing an approach, including the procedures, activities, and materials used. Methods are often more practical and concrete than approaches. Examples of methods include:

- The Audio-Lingual Method
- The Silent Way
- Total Physical Response (TPR)

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Techniques: Specific tools or strategies used to support a method or approach. Techniques are often more specific and tactical than methods. Examples of techniques include:

- Role-playing
- Group work
- Authentic materials
- Flashcards

Interactive Method

A learner-centered, communicative approach that emphasizes interaction and dialogue

Acquisition vs. Learning

- Acquisition: A natural, subconscious process of language acquisition, similar to how children learn their first language.
- Learning: A conscious, intentional process of language learning, often involving formal instruction.

Competence vs. Performance

- Competence: The language knowledge and abilities a learner possesses.
- Performance: The actual language use and production by the learner.

Deductive vs. Inductive

- Deductive: A top-down approach, where learners are taught rules and then apply them to language production.
- Inductive: A bottom-up approach, where learners discover language rules through exposure and practice.

 **Pavlovian Conditioning:** Ivan Pavlov's theory that associations are made between stimuli and responses (e.g., bell rings, dog salivates).

 **Classical Conditioning:** John Watson's extension of Pavlov's theory to include language learning (e.g., associating words with meanings).

 **Reciprocal Determinism:** Albert Bandura's theory that behavior is influenced by the environment and vice versa.

 **Operant Conditioning:** B.F. Skinner's theory that behavior is modified by its consequences (rewards or punishments).

 **Mediation Theory:** A theory that language learning is facilitated by mediators (e.g., teachers, materials) that help learners connect language forms with meanings.

 **The Law Effect:** A theory that language learning is influenced by the learner's environment and social interactions.

Nativism and LAD

- Nativism: The idea that language acquisition is innate, and humans have a natural ability to acquire language.
- LAD (Language Acquisition Device): Noam Chomsky's hypothetical module that facilitates language acquisition.

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Chomsky's Criticism on Behaviourism

Chomsky argued that behaviorism cannot explain language acquisition, as it is too complex and creative.

Rene Descartes Concept of Idea

The idea that knowledge is innate and language acquisition is a process of discovery.

Transcendental Idealism

The idea that knowledge is shaped by the mind, not just external stimuli.

The Lenneberg Theory and Competence and Performance

- Competence: The language knowledge and abilities a learner possesses.
- Performance: The actual language use and production by the learner.
- Lenneberg Theory: Eric Lenneberg's theory that language acquisition is limited by a critical period (children's language acquisition is more efficient than adults').

 **Dispelling Myths:** Challenging common misconceptions about language acquisition.

 **Critical Period Hypothesis:** The Critical Period Hypothesis (CPH) proposes that there is a limited time period during which language acquisition can occur easily and naturally, after which it becomes more difficult or impossible. This hypothesis was first proposed by Eric Lenneberg in 1967 and has been the subject of much debate and research in the field of linguistics and language acquisition.

Key aspects of the Critical Period Hypothesis:

- Age limitation: The hypothesis suggests that there is a critical age range (roughly between birth and puberty) during which language acquisition is most efficient and effective.
- Language acquisition window: The idea that there is a limited time period during which the brain is most receptive to language input and can acquire language easily and naturally.
- Brain plasticity: The hypothesis is based on the idea that the brain's ability to reorganize and adapt (neuroplasticity) is highest during this critical period.
- Language universals: The hypothesis suggests that the critical period is related to the acquisition of language universals, which are the fundamental building blocks of language.

 **Introduction to Universal Grammar:** UG-based approaches to Second Language Acquisition (SLA) are theories and models that draw on the concept of Universal Grammar (UG) to explain how learners acquire a second language. UG, proposed by Noam Chomsky, refers to the innate, genetically determined capacity for language acquisition that all humans possess.

Key features of UG-based approaches to SLA:

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- Innatism: The idea that language acquisition is facilitated by an innate language acquisition device (LAD) that provides a universal framework for language development.
- Poverty of the stimulus: The argument that the input language learners receive is insufficient to explain the complexity of language they acquire, suggesting that UG fills in the gaps.
- Linguistic universals: The idea that certain linguistic features and structures are universal across languages, reflecting the influence of UG.
- Parameter setting: The process by which learners set the parameters of their L2 grammar, guided by UG and the input they receive.
- Language acquisition device (LAD): A hypothetical module that contains UG and guides language acquisition.

UG based approaches to SLA:

- Generative SLA: Focuses on the role of UG in generating linguistic knowledge and the acquisition of L2 grammar.
- Minimalist Program: A theoretical framework that seeks to explain language acquisition and linguistic representation in terms of UG and minimalist principles.
- Universal Grammar and the Acquisition of L2 Phonology: Explores the role of UG in the acquisition of L2 phonology and the development of L2 phonological systems.

 **General Learning Theory and Principles:** Language acquisition is a result of general cognitive processes

Language and Cognition-Cognitive Perceptual Processes

Here are some key aspects of language and cognition:

- Perception: The process of receiving and interpreting sensory information, such as hearing and seeing.
- Attention: The ability to focus on specific stimuli or tasks, filtering out irrelevant information.
- Memory: The capacity to store and retrieve language information, including vocabulary, grammar, and phonology.
- Processing: The mental operations that allow us to understand, produce, and manipulate language.
- Executive functions: High-level cognitive processes, such as planning, problem-solving, and decision-making, that influence language use.

Cognitive perceptual processes involved in language include:

- Phonological processing: The ability to perceive, produce, and manipulate speech sounds.

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- Orthographic processing: The ability to recognize and produce written language.
- Semantic processing: The ability to understand and manipulate meaning.
- Syntactic processing: The ability to understand and produce grammatical structures.
- Pragmatic processing: The ability to understand and use language in context, considering speaker intentions and social norms.

Strategies of Development:

- **Reception:** Learners receive language input through listening and reading.
- **Production:** Learners produce language through speaking and writing.
- **Imitation:** Learners imitate native speakers' language forms and structures.
- **Experimentation:** Learners try out new language forms and structures.
- **Practice:** Learners repeat and reinforce language forms and structures.

strategies of development include:

- **Cognitive strategies:** Using mental processes like attention, memory, and problem-solving to learn language.
- **Metacognitive strategies:** Thinking about and managing one's own language learning process.
- **Social strategies:** Using social interactions and relationships to learn language.
- **Affective strategies:** Using emotions and motivation to learn language.

 **Piagetian Stages of Development:** Learners progress through stages of cognitive development (Jean Piaget).

1. Sensorimotor Stage (0-2 years):

- Infants and young children learn through sensory experiences and motor activities.
- They understand the world through sensory inputs and motor responses.

2. Preoperational Stage (2-7 years):

- Children begin to use symbols and language, but their thinking is still egocentric.
- They have difficulty taking other people's perspectives and understanding causal relationships.

3. Concrete Operational Stage (7-11 years):

- Children develop the ability to think logically and solve problems using concrete objects and events.
- They can understand cause-and-effect relationships and classify objects into categories.

4. Formal Operational Stage (11-15 years and beyond):

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- Adolescents and adults develop the ability to think abstractly and reason logically about abstract concepts.
- They can solve complex problems, understand hypothetical situations, and reason about abstract ideas.

✚ **Multi-Store Model (Richard Shiffrin) on Cognitivism:** Information is processed and stored in multiple stages.

✚ **The Competition Model and the Associative-Cognitive CREED Theory(Nick Ellis):** Language acquisition is a result of competition and association between linguistic forms.

✚ **Rumelhart and McLelland on Connectionism:** Language acquisition is a result of connections between nodes in a network.

✚ **Newell and Simon's Theory of Information Processing:** Language acquisition is a result of information processing and problem-solving.

✚ **Constructivism:** General Learning Theory : Constructivism is a theory that states that learners construct their own knowledge and understanding through experience and social interaction.

✚ **Principles of Constructivism:**

- Learners are active participants in the learning process.
- Knowledge is constructed through experience and social interaction.
- Learning is a process of constructing meaning, not just acquiring information.

✚ **John Dewey's Notion of Experiential Education:** Emphasizes the importance of hands-on experience and experimentation in learning. Learning is an active process, not just a passive reception of information.

✚ **Fredrick's Schematic Account of Memory Demonstrate:** Memory is organized in a schematic framework, with new information building on existing knowledge. Learning is a process of elaborating and refining existing schemata.

✚ **Jean Piaget and Constructivism**

- Piaget's theory of constructivism emphasizes the role of adaptation and disequilibrium in learning
- Adaptation: The process of adjusting to new information and experiences.
- Disequilibrium: The state of being out of balance, which motivates learners to adapt and construct new knowledge.

✚ **Bruner's Idea of Scaffolding and Discovery Learning:**

Scaffolding: Providing temporary support and guidance to facilitate learning.

Discovery Learning: Learners construct their own knowledge through active exploration and experimentation.

✚ **Bruner on Teaching Influencing Learning:** Teaching should facilitate learning, not just transmit information. Teachers should provide scaffolding and support to help learners construct their own knowledge.

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- ✚ **Bandura's Socio-Cognitive Model of Human Behaviour [Self Efficacy]:** Self-Efficacy: The belief in one's ability to perform tasks and achieve goals. Learning is influenced by self-efficacy, as well as observation, imitation, and reinforcement.
- ✚ **Understanding Self-Efficacy:** Self-efficacy is a key factor in motivation and learning. Learners with high self-efficacy are more likely to take risks and persist in the face of challenges.
- ✚ **David Ausubel's Subsumption Theory:**
 - Learning is a process of subsuming new information into existing knowledge structures.
 - New information is linked to existing knowledge, and learning is a process of elaborating and refining existing schemata
- ✚ **Metacognition:** The ability to think about and reflect on one's own thinking and learning.
- ✚ **Script Theory:** Learning is a process of constructing and refining mental scripts, or frameworks for understanding and interpreting experience.
- ✚ **General Theory, 5 Hypotheses and Factors:** The general theory is that learning is an active process of constructing knowledge and meaning.

The 5 hypotheses are:

- Learners are active participants in the learning process.
- Knowledge is constructed through experience and social interaction.
- Learning is a process of constructing meaning, not just acquiring information.
- Learners use existing knowledge and experience to construct new knowledge.
- Learning is influenced by self-efficacy, motivation, and interest.

Factors that influence learning include:

- Prior knowledge and experience
- Motivation and interest
- Self-efficacy and confidence
- Social and cultural context
- Teaching and learning strategies

✚ **Acquisition vs. Learning Hypothesis:**

The Natural Approach: A language learning approach that emphasizes exposure to natural language input and spontaneous communication.

Acquisition vs. Learning Hypothesis: Stephen Krashen's hypothesis that language acquisition is a natural, subconscious process, while language learning is a conscious, intentional process.

✚ **The Natural Order Hypothesis and the Input Hypothesis:**

Natural Order Hypothesis: The idea that language acquisition follows a natural, predictable order, regardless of instruction.

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Input Hypothesis: Krashen's hypothesis that comprehensible input is the primary driving force behind language acquisition.

+ **The Monitor Hypothesis and the Affective Filter Hypothesis:**

Monitor Hypothesis: The idea that learners have a conscious monitor that edits and corrects language output.

Affective Filter Hypothesis: Krashen's hypothesis that learners' emotional state (motivation, anxiety, etc.) affects their ability to acquire language.

+ **Communicative Language Teaching (CLT) and Criticism:**

CLT: An approach that emphasizes authentic communication and real-life language use.

Criticism: CLT has been criticized for neglecting grammar instruction and focusing too much on fluency.

+ **Vygotsky and M.A.K Halliday:** Sociocultural theorists who emphasize the role of culture and social interaction in language learning.

+ **Acculturation Model and Steps in Acculturation:** The process of adapting to a new culture and language.

+ **Situated Learning and Language Socialization:**

Situated Learning: Learning that occurs in a specific context and is influenced by that context.

Language Socialization: The process of acquiring language and cultural norms through social interaction.

+ **BASIC LANGUAGE COGNITION (BLC) VS. HIGHER LANGUAGE:**

Basic Language Cognition: The ability to process and understand language at a basic level.

Higher Language Cognition: The ability to use language for complex cognitive tasks, such as problem-solving and critical thinking.

+ **Basic Language Cognition:** Refers to the ability to process and understand language at a basic level, including phonology, syntax, and vocabulary. These can be implied by:

- Providing comprehensible input and opportunities for spontaneous communication.
- Emphasizing authentic communication and real-life language use.
- Recognizing the role of culture and social interaction in language learning.
- Adapting instruction to learners' emotional state and motivation.
- Focusing on both basic language cognition and higher language cognition.

+ **Native Speaker Construct:** The idea that there is a single, monolithic "native speaker" construct is problematic, as it overlooks differences among language learners.

+ **Differences Among Language Learners:** Learners vary in their language background, motivation, and learning styles, which affect their language acquisition.

+ **Generative School:** Focuses on the innate ability to generate language rules and structures.

+ **Usage-Based School:** Emphasizes the role of input, frequency, and practice in language learning.

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- ✚ **Generative vs. Usage-Based School Explanation:** Generative school emphasizes the learner's internal language faculty, while usage-based school emphasizes the role of external factors like input and practice.
- ✚ **Dell Hymes Communicative Competence:** Communicative competence includes linguistic, sociolinguistic, and strategic competence.
- ✚ **Bachman Communicative Language Ability (CLA):** Communicative language ability (CLA) consists of organizational, pragmatic, and psycholinguistic components.
- ✚ **Types of Competencies:** Linguistic, sociolinguistic, discourse, strategic, and symbolic competence.
- ✚ **Canale and Swain's Model of Communicative Competence:** Includes linguistic, sociolinguistic, and strategic competence.
- ✚ **Bachman and Palmer Model of Language Proficiency:** Includes language knowledge, language ability, and metacognitive strategies.
- ✚ **Celce-Murcia Models of Communicative Competence:** Emphasize the importance of pragmatic and sociolinguistic competence.
- ✚ **Kramsch and Whiteside's Symbolic Competence:** Highlights the role of symbolic knowledge in language learning.

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